



Montenegro, and Greece. The Albanian language contains many Latin and Greek words but it does not really resemble any of the Slavonic languages. Albanians are proud that for centuries their shared ethnicity has

united them above their religious differences. Albania was isolated and relatively poor under communist rule, but with communism's demise in the 1990s, its standard of living started steadily improving.

TRADITIONAL MUSIC

Albanian folk music shows Persian and Turkish influences. One popular instrument is the *çifteli*, the long-necked two-stringed mandolin shown here.



GETTING AROUND

Horses and carts are still a common means of transportation in Albania, which is quite poor by European standards. About two-thirds of Albanians live in rural areas and the rest in cities. Hundreds of villages have no access to telephones either, because after the communist regime ended many phone wires were cut and used to build fences instead.



RURAL LIFE

Agriculture is responsible for bringing in half of the money made in Albania, yet most Albanian farms consist of small, family-owned plots of land where traditional methods are used and people and animals do the work that, elsewhere in Europe, would be done by machine.

